



Microsoft Teams

Unlock the true potential of this powerful collaboration app

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MICROSOFT TEAMS IS A POWERFUL COMMUNICATION AND COLLABORATION APPLICATION that essentially combines workplace chat, video conferences, file storage and collaboration, and application integration. Recently, on April 21, Microsoft 365 replaced Office 365 as the company's subscription service for tools such as Word, Excel, and Outlook. A consumer version of Teams is now available as well for free, while the Microsoft 365 Business versions give users access to a premium version of Teams. The collaboration app has a ton of organisation and data sharing options that are useful not just for companies, but also for the average consumer that uses the app to learn remotely or keep in touch with their family. Nevertheless, it is still largely catered towards

the corporate crowd. Here are the best tips and tricks you can use to enhance your experience when using Microsoft Teams.



CHANGE THE BACKGROUND

If you are working from home, which let's face it... you probably are, you may not find appropriate backgrounds for your video calls. However, you can actually alter the backgrounds with Microsoft Teams to ensure that you don't end up displaying your messy surroundings in the background. To add a different background, hit the ellipsis (three-dot) button during a video call and select 'Show background effects'. You will see a couple of default backgrounds on the right-hand

side of the screen. Select a background and hit the 'Preview' button to ensure it is appropriate. Now, hit 'Apply' after selecting the background. To select a locally-saved image as your background, go to 'Show background effects' and then select 'Add new'. You can now pick a .JPG, .PNG, or .BMP file from your PC.

Besides simply changing the background, you can also choose to blur the background during a video conference. To do this, click on the ellipsis button during a video call and then select 'Blur background' if your camera is already on. If the camera is not yet activated, select the 'Start camera with blurred background' option. Additionally, if you wish to blur the background before



A video on Microsoft's YouTube channel demonstrating Background Blur on Teams

getting on a call, click the second purple slider from the left on the call joining screen. This will enable the background blur feature.



REARRANGE TEAMS IN THE ORDER YOU PREFER

If you use Microsoft Teams a lot, your list of teams can actually get pretty crowded and messy. You may find that you spend too much time looking for a particular team on your list, which can be aggravating. To avoid this, you can reorder your teams list based on importance. Surprisingly, a lot of people don't know that this option is available on both the Desktop and Mobile version of Microsoft Teams. On the desktop version, simply select the Teams tab from the left-hand-side and then drag the teams anywhere on the list. On mobile, simply tap and hold a team name until it's selected and then drag and drop it where you desire.



PIN YOUR FREQUENTLY-USED OFFICE 365 APPS

One of the USPs of Microsoft Teams is the ability to integrate the whole suite of Office 365 apps on the platform. You can add relevant apps to different Teams conversations. So, if your organisation regularly uses Trello, a project management tool, to review the board and work on a project collaboratively, you can pin the app within the chat or channel. To do this, select the ellipsis button beneath the box where you type messages and choose an app from the list. If you can't find the app you're looking for, simply search for it. Now select the app and click on 'Add' and the icon will